

defence NTR

SPY VERSUS SPY

Eight years after the Kargil war, India's key technical intelligence agency is still grounded due to a bitter turf war with RAW

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

On May 17, 1999, when the first Gulfstream jets of the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) flew over the 150-km swathe in the Kargil sector, their cameras picked up shockingly candid images of the Pakistani intrusion—mule trains, machine gun nests, gun emplacements, helicopters sitting on helipads—all this 10 km inside the Indian territory. It was a colossal intelligence failure that an operation on such a massive scale by Pakistan had reached this stage without anyone in India being aware of it. The reason: India's multiple agencies with technical snooping capabilities reported to different heads. There were 45 different intelligence inputs but no single agency to piece them together.

Hence, in October 2004, the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) approved a detailed note which would result in the biggest intelligence shake-up since 1968 when RAW was formed. It approved the setting up of a National Technical Research Organisation (NTR), a super-technical spy organisation modelled on the US National Security Agency (NSA), which would be the repository of the nation's technical intelligence (TECHINT) assets—spy satellites, UAVs and spy planes. The new agency would prevent the recurrence of a Kargil-type fiasco.

Nearly three years later, it wouldn't be wrong to call it the Notional Technical Research Organisation. Key cabinet approvals from the note have not been implemented because of a bitter turf war with the well-established



SITTING PRETTY: Pakistan's Northern Light Infantry in Kargil

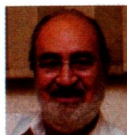
RAW, particularly its airborne and technical division—the Aviation Research Centre (ARC). The only significant assets it has are spy satellites but no spy planes, another vital component of TECHINT.

Early last year, NTR finished evaluating four new long-range surveillance aircraft to be purchased from Canada's Bombardier. Packed with the newest all-weather Israeli radars and sensors, these aircraft could datalink intelligence in real time and would be a generation ahead of the ARC's ageing fleet of Gulfstream IIIs equipped with wash-and-process film cameras.

Over one-and-a-half years later, the agency is yet to hear from the Government on the aircraft or its proposal to acquire helicopters. The word is that RAW has stonewalled the acquisition because it is anxious to protect its

in-house technical division—which also snoops on nuclear tests and missile launches in the neighbourhood making it a vital component of the Nuclear Command Authority. So, in a classic dichotomy, the Government now receives airborne intelligence from RAW and satellite imagery from NTR, going against the very logic of having a single agency for technical intelligence. The agency is allowed to collect data but not process or interpret it. By now, the organisation should have been the nodal agency for cyber warfare but has been forbidden from hacking or cyber snooping simply because they are not part of the seven agencies authorised to monitor communication facilities.

The CCS note laid out an exhaustive 10-year perspective plan for its growth—its charter, manpower, functions and special equipment acquisition which flowed from the recommendations of the Kargil Review Committee (KRC) headed by K. Subrahmanyam, which decried RAW's monopoly on external intelligence. It commented adversely on the wisdom of saddling one agency with multiple responsibilities of human, communication, imagery



“Key decisions were not implemented because other agencies refused to part with assets.”

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